

Ph.D. Scholarship and Research Policy — Fellowship Guidelines

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These guidelines describe how the Ph.D. Scholarship and Research Policy is applied in practice. They explain fellowship norms, eligibility, supervision expectations, research milestones and the conditions under which awards are continued, renewed or ended.

1. Introduction

The scholarship programme supports doctoral candidates who commit to full-time research in a recognised institution. It is designed to reduce financial barriers to doctoral study, encourage rigorous research and increase the number of qualified researchers contributing to the higher education system and to national knowledge development.

2. Purpose

These guidelines operationalise the policy by setting clear norms for fellowships, explaining how supervisors and candidates are expected to work together, defining milestones that make progress visible and describing the circumstances under which awards are renewed, suspended or ended. They aim to make the programme fair, transparent and accountable.

3. Eligibility

- The candidate must hold a postgraduate qualification appropriate to the proposed doctoral research.
- Admission to a recognised Ph.D. programme must be confirmed.
- A supervisor must be assigned and the research proposal approved by the institution before application.
- The candidate must not hold another full-time scholarship that covers the same period.
- Candidates with prior doctoral research experience beyond a defined period may be subject to specific eligibility limits.

4. Fellowship Duration and Stipend

Fellowships are awarded for the normal registration period for the Ph.D. programme, and may be extended in defined circumstances. The fellowship consists of a monthly stipend and an annual research contingency. The contingency must be used for research-related costs such as fieldwork, laboratory consumables, attendance at academic events approved by the institution, and the purchase of essential research materials.

5. Application and Selection

1. The institution verifies that the candidate is duly enrolled and has an approved proposal.
2. The application, including a brief research outline and supervisor endorsement, is submitted to the funding body.
3. An expert panel reviews the proposal against criteria of originality, feasibility and potential contribution.
4. Selection is made and communicated within the published timeline.
5. Acceptance is confirmed by the candidate within the stipulated time, after which the fellowship is offered to the next eligible candidate.

6. Supervision Requirements

Every fellow must have a designated supervisor with appropriate expertise and an active research profile. Supervisors are expected to provide regular guidance, review progress against the agreed plan, guide the candidate through the milestones described below and confirm the candidate's progress for renewal. Where co-supervision is in place, responsibilities are formally agreed.

7. Research Milestones

Fellowship renewal is linked to the achievement of research milestones. These are reviewed annually by an institutional committee and verified before the renewal decision.

- End of Year 1: Literature review substantially completed; methodology refined; first internal progress report submitted.
- End of Year 2: Data collection or core research activity underway; institutional progress seminar delivered; methodology documented.
- End of Year 3: Analysis substantially completed; at least one paper submitted to a recognised publication venue; progress reviewed by institutional committee.
- End of Year 4: Draft thesis chapters reviewed; paper accepted or resubmission confirmed; submission plan agreed.
- Year 5 (if approved): Thesis submitted and viva arrangements initiated.

8. Milestone Evaluation and Renewal

Each year, the candidate submits a progress report and a brief presentation. The supervisor provides a supporting assessment. An institutional committee evaluates the submission and may: (i) confirm renewal; (ii) place the candidate on supervised progress improvement; or (iii) recommend termination where progress is seriously deficient or the milestone has not been substantially met despite an improvement plan.

9. Thesis Submission and Final Evaluation

Fellowship support may continue through the thesis writing period, up to the maximum permitted duration, provided the candidate is making progress towards submission. The thesis must be evaluated by external examiners approved by the institution. Any delay beyond the permitted period is covered by the institution and is not borne by the fellowship.

10. Publication and Output Expectations

- At least one peer-reviewed publication or equivalent output is expected before thesis submission.
- Institutional seminars and departmental presentations form part of the research training experience.
- Candidate presentations at recognised conferences are encouraged and may be funded through the contingency, subject to supervisor approval.
- All outputs must acknowledge the fellowship support where applicable.

11. Reporting and Transparency

The Higher Education Department receives anonymised annual reports from participating institutions covering fellowship numbers, progress outcomes, publication outputs and any issues arising. Institutions must maintain clear records of candidate progress and evaluation decisions for audit purposes.

12. Review

These guidelines are reviewed as part of the wider policy review cycle, or sooner if there are material changes in doctoral training practice, funding conditions or national research priorities.

13. Contact and Support Note

Candidates and supervisors with questions about these guidelines should contact the research coordination office of their institution. The Higher Education Department's fellowship support cell is available for queries on policy interpretation and for reporting concerns about programme implementation.